Return of a NATIVE

Once the pride of the Maratha empire, the Bhimthadi horse had faded into oblivion in the past 200 years. Its recognition now as a separate indigenous breed could spell a reversal of fortunes for the steed

BY DHAVAL KULKARNI



The six horses come galloping along the low-roofed stable building in Baramati, Maharashtra—a black stallion and a bay-coloured mare, followed by a white and a dun-skinned pair. Pelts gleaming, manes flowing, tails flying and hooves pounding the dust...they appear to be a force of nature. Hand-picked specimens of the famed Bhimthadi or Deccani horse, one can almost imagine the creatures among their ancestors in the 17th and 18th centuries, in a troop of Maratha horsemen, charging at the enemy and driving them off the field.

Deriving their name from the Bhima river in whose basin they originated (*thadi* means riverbank), their dash and pace made the Bhimthadis a mainstay of the famed, and dreaded, Maratha cavalry when the empire held sway over much of India. Simultaneously, their sturdiness, the ability to cover long distances on little fodder and carry loads one and a half times their body weight also made them a favoured mount—"one of the best breeds in India", in the words of colonial-era botanist Sir George Watt. However, with the decline of the Maratha confederacy, the advent of modern firearms and imported breeds, the Bhimthadi lost favour, its role reduced to being pack animals for shepherds and mounts at pilgrimage centres and